

Study Guide for PSYC 1111: Introduction to Health Psychology - Unit 6

Overview

This unit explores the psychological dimensions of chronic illnesses, focusing on their impact on physical, emotional, and social well-being. It examines how psychology influences the onset, progression, treatment, and adaptation to conditions like obesity, coronary heart disease (CHD), cancer, and arthritis. Key themes include resilience, hope, psychosocial adjustment, and the integration of traditional and complementary approaches. The materials highlight that while chronic illnesses may be long-term, psychological strategies can enhance quality of life and outcomes.

Consider how psychology fosters resilience, stress management, and behavioral changes in managing chronic diseases.

Key Questions to Reflect On

- How does psychology contribute to the onset, progression, treatment, and management of chronic illnesses?
- What factors enable positive adaptation to chronic health conditions?
- How do resilience and determination affect coping with chronic diseases?

Summarized Readings

1. Helgeson, V. S., & Zajdel, M. (2017). *Adjusting to Chronic Health Conditions*. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 68, 545–571.

- **Key Focus:** Defines chronic illnesses as long-term conditions impacting physical function, self-identity, and psychosocial well-being.
- **Main Points:**
 - Chronic illnesses disrupt daily life, leading to emotional challenges like stress, depression, and social isolation.
 - Adaptation factors: personal traits (e.g., optimism, resilience), social support, coping strategies (problem-focused vs. emotion-focused), and resource access.
 - Positive adaptation involves acceptance, behavioral changes, and building resilience to maintain quality of life.

- Interventions like therapy, support groups, and mindfulness foster adjustment.
- **Digestible Takeaway:** Chronic illness affects more than the body—it’s a psychological journey. Build support networks and adaptive mindsets to thrive.
- **Link:** Access via [UoPeople Library](#) (login required; full text not publicly available).

2. Ogden, J. (2019). *The Psychology of Health and Illness: An Open Access Course*. McGraw Hill. (Chapter 6: The Role of Psychology in Chronic Illnesses such as Obesity, Coronary Heart Disease (CHD), and Cancer, pp. 69–82).

- **Key Focus:** Examines psychology’s role in three chronic illnesses: obesity, CHD, and cancer.
- **Main Points:**
 - **Obesity:** Stress eating, body image issues, and habits contribute. Management uses cognitive-behavioral therapy (CBT) for habit change and motivation.
 - **CHD:** Stress, Type A personality (competitive, impatient), and depression increase risk. Interventions include stress reduction (e.g., relaxation) and lifestyle changes.
 - **Cancer:** Emotional responses (fear, denial) affect treatment adherence. Psychology aids coping through support, positive thinking, and survivorship strategies.
 - Psychology influences prevention (behavior change), progression (stress management), and management (adherence, emotional support).
- **Digestible Takeaway:** Psychology shapes prevention, living with, and treating physical diseases. Use goal-setting and therapy to manage behaviors and emotions.
- **Link:** Available via [UoPeople Library](#) (login required; open access course, but specific chapter access may be restricted).

Summarized Video Resources

1. TEDx Talks (2018). *Confronting Chronic Disease and Refusing to Give Up* | Susannah Meadows | TEDxNashville

- **Overview:** Susannah Meadows shares her son’s recovery from “incurable” juvenile idiopathic arthritis, challenging the notion of permanent chronic diseases.
- **Key Points:**
 - Her son recovered using traditional medicine and complementary therapies (e.g., diet changes).

- Stories of overcoming “irreversible” conditions like food allergies, multiple sclerosis (MS), epilepsy, and rheumatoid arthritis (RA).
- Emphasizes hope, perseverance, agency, and exploring alternatives like nutrition and mind-body connections.
- Research highlights the brain’s role in healing and rejecting “incurable” labels.
- **Digestible Takeaway:** Combine science, hope, and innovation. Persistence and open-mindedness can lead to breakthroughs in chronic disease management. (Inspirational for resilience.)
- **Link:** [Watch on YouTube](#) (15 minutes).

2. Yahoo Life (2018). *How to Cope with Chronic Illness: ‘Your Disease Does Not Define You’*

- **Overview:** Social worker Sarah Johnson discusses emotional and practical coping strategies for chronic illnesses (e.g., heart disease, diabetes, MS, cancer).
- **Key Points:**
 - Process emotions like grief or anger post-diagnosis.
 - Stress worsens symptoms; manage with mindfulness, light exercise, and hobbies.
 - Build resilience through healthy eating (fruits, veggies, lean proteins; avoid processed foods), boundaries, and self-care.
 - Join support groups for connection and shared experiences.
 - Your illness is part of you but doesn’t define your identity or potential.
- **Digestible Takeaway:** Focus on controllable aspects—emotions, diet, and support. Practical tips like feeling your feelings and seeking community empower coping.
- **Link:** [Watch on YouTube](#) (3 minutes).

Checklist for Unit 6

- **Readings:** Review articles and chapter for psychological models (e.g., adaptation theories).
- **Videos:** Watch for real-life resilience examples ([TEDxNashville](#), [Yahoo Life](#)).
- **Activities:** Participate in Discussion Forum (share thoughts on psychological roles in chronic illness).
- **Assessments:** Complete Self-Quiz and Graded Quiz.
- **Reflection:** Journal how psychological factors apply to your life or others’.
- **Due Dates:** All activities close Wednesdays at 11:55 PM GMT-5 (use [UoPeople clock](#)).

Additional Tips for Study

- **Make It Digestible:** Break readings into sections; highlight psychological vs. physical aspects.
- **Connect Concepts:** Link to prior units (e.g., stress from Unit 3).
- **Resources:** Access full texts via [UoPeople Library](#); rewatch videos for motivation.
- **Create Your PDF:** Copy this guide into a tool like Google Docs or Microsoft Word, add images (e.g., YouTube thumbnails), and export as PDF.

This guide condenses Unit 6 into key insights for efficient review. For further details or expansions, refer to the linked resources or contact your instructor via [UoPeople Moodle](#).